Europe is preparing a more robust response to Russia's hybrid war

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【メール原文】

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EU will expand its tools to counter Russia’s escalating hybrid war

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European countries will consider a broader set of retaliatory measures—including the seizure of Russian assets frozen at Euroclear—as Russia's hybrid campaign intensifies, with a mass-casualty event the most likely trigger for crossing that threshold.
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Russia’s hybrid war is unlikely to escalate into an outright “hot” war, but it will inflict considerable material and psychological harm in an already tense European political environment.
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Amid a deteriorating US-Ukraine relationship, the Administration of Donald Trump will also continue to play a largely passive role in response to Russia’s hybrid attacks.

Russia will keep escalating its hybrid war against European countries. As recent cyberattacks and sabotage incidents across Europe show, Moscow will continue to use the full range of hybrid tools, including cyberattacks, arson, sabotage, disinformation campaigns, and assassinations. Russian bot activity in Western countries that supports illiberal, extremist, and populist parties will resume after a recent Ukrainian attack on Russian technology firm Yandex revealed and disrupted the flow of that harmful online content. Russia will also seek to threaten and possibly kill leaders of European arms companies in order to raise the political and personal costs of Europe’s coordinated military buildup.

Europe will strengthen defenses against hybrid war but will remain vulnerable in the near term. The initial focus will remain on defensive measures, such as hardening IT systems and enhancing security for critical infrastructure. Because Russia’s hybrid attacks are hard to attribute and difficult to answer in kind, European countries will struggle to impose immediate costs and restore deterrence. The main challenge will be to raise costs on Russia without risking broader escalation.

That said, Europe is building capabilities to counter hybrid attacks, including expanded cyber intelligence operations. Over time, this will give Europe a broader set of options for responding to hybrid threats in both NATO and EU contexts. Germany is revising its restrictive legal framework for covert intelligence operations, while France and several other European countries already appear to be conducting offensive counterintelligence operations.

EU-NATO response options to Russian escalation

Russia’s hybrid escalation will sharpen Europe’s debate over seizing frozen assets. Work on crafting a political compromise that shields Belgium, Euroclear’s host country and regulator, from retaliation and reputational damage is ongoing but will require careful diplomacy and creative financial structuring. For now, European governments are most likely to use the assets as collateral for loans and disburse the proceeds to Kyiv. Nonetheless, Eurasia Group places the odds of seizing the underlying capital at 30%, with the likelihood rising. The odds would increase sharply if there were a mass-casualty event in the EU. This could strengthen the political resolve to overcome obstacles and respond more forcefully. Asset seizure would also give fiscally constrained European governments a way to support Ukraine’s war effort without drawing on regular budgets.

More conventional responses include broader sanctions and stricter enforcement. These also include a visa ban on Russian nationals, a total trade and energy embargo that ends the remaining import and export exemptions, broader sanctions on Russia’s nuclear sector, increased fiscal support for Ukraine, and faster attribution of hybrid attacks.

The US will remain noncommittal on Russia’s hybrid escalation. Washington has avoided publicly siding with Europe after recent cyberattacks and sabotage incidents, including a failed attack on Germany’s Leipzig airport that could have caused catastrophic damage and loss of life. During a late-August trip to Moscow, CIA Director John Ratcliffe warned the Kremlin not to attack NATO territory, while NATO reinforced that message with a military exercise near Russia’s Kaliningrad enclave. Even so, the US has notably stopped short of condemning Russia’s escalating hybrid activity in Europe.

Russia’s hybrid escalation will continue to advance both tactical and strategic goals. These efforts aim to punish European countries that support Ukraine, while spreading fear and uncertainty among voters. Moscow also seeks to weaken Europe’s broad political consensus that defending Ukraine is essential to European security. Through support for far-right and far-left parties, along with a coordinated disinformation campaign on social media, Russia aims to strengthen forces that oppose continued fiscal and military aid to Ukraine.

Moscow wants to show that resisting Russian pressure is futile, that Ukraine cannot win, and that European governments should adopt a less confrontational approach. The Kremlin also seeks to portray Washington as an unreliable ally, thereby deepening transatlantic divisions—a long-standing strategic goal. President Vladimir Putin will continue to use rising conflict with neighboring countries to tighten his regime’s hold on power at home.

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